

Some less known facts about Sunil Raina

Turning point of life: Mastering reading and writing English

What if not a communications professional: A politician

Political leader I like: Narendra Modi, politics apart

Go-to dish: Kashmiri Rajma Chawal

Actress I find the most beautiful: Juhi Chawla

Actress whose work I enjoy the most: Madhuri Dixit

Actor I like to see perform: Amitabh Bachan

Delhi or Kashmir: Kashmir

Books I Read: Business, History, and Mythology

A book I can read again and again: Eating The Big Fish

Favourite cartoon: He-Man

where he enjoyed rajma chawal for two years.

He went to Hughes Telecom for a walk-in interview that he saw being advertised in a newspaper, but was asked to leave after the group discussion round. Thinking that he was not able to impress the company, he continued with the process of giving interviews at other companies. Mobile phones at that time were a luxury, and all that the world relied on for communication were landlines. Everywhere Raina went for an interview, he left the landline number owned by his landlord.

One day, his landlord called him and told that a company had called and wanted to speak to him about offering Raina a job, but as destiny would have it, the landlord was not able to remember the name of the organisation.

"My landlord did not remember the name of the company that had called and left a message for me. While I was also not sure about which interview I had given the best, I took a chance and went to Hughes Telecom, looking for answers. Though I was sure that this would not be the company, they had actually called to offer me a job in the sales and marketing department," he shares, smiling.

He adds, "I was initially given the role of a sales trainee for six months before being given a higher designation after standing second best performer in my entire batch."

Hughes Telecom was later taken over by Tata Group. Raina spent around six years with Hughes Telecom and Tata Group. Raina's first job, however, was as a teacher. He started

teaching for a monthly salary of one hundred rupees when he was pursuing his graduation in Jammu.

Lava happened over single malt

Raina, today, has become the face of one the most promising smartphone brands in India. Lava, as we know it, is also a participant in the production linked scheme for manufacturing of smartphones in the country. The scheme, close to the heart of our prime minister Narendra Modi, envisages to create champion smartphone brands from India, and Lava is a part of the same.

Narendra Modi also happens to be the politician Raina admires greatly. He believes that the way PM Modi has risen in his life and his process of doing things is a success lesson for all entrepreneurs out there.

The story of how Sunil Raina got associated with Lava involves an evening with friends and single malt whiskey. Vishal Sehgal, who is one of the co-founders of Lava, called Raina one fine day and explained everything about Lava and his plans for the same. This was on the same call that Sehgal invited Raina for evening drinks and a dinner meet.

Do note here, Sehgal used to be the reporting manager of Raina at Airtel. Raina fondly looks up to Sehgal as his brother, mentor, and guide. Interestingly, the designations of Sehgal and Raina at Airtel, at that time, were CEO and marketing head, respectively. "He called me and I was at Gurgaon at that time. He said let's have a drink together. I went to him and he told me to join the team of Lava," explains Raina.

What triggered Raina to join the Lava team and leave a great job at one of the best companies to work in India was the respect and admiration he had for Sehgal. Second, as Raina explains, the team at Lava was very clear about the vision they had for the company. He explains that his past always compelled him to do something about the country, and he saw that chance with Lava.

Please note that it was a time when the country was filled with brands that called imported smartphones as Indian, white labelled them and sold them in India. Lava, as per Raina, from the very beginning excited him with its vision, which was to be truly Indian. For the records, Lava was the first company to pull out all of its R&D setup from China and set base in India.

"I always loved hoisting and carrying the Indian flag back in Jammu and Kashmir. It was clear to me that Lava would be my chance to do something for the country. We are now trying to build a global brand here in India," says Sunil.

This was the moment where I jokingly asked him what he was drinking that evening when he made the decision to join Lava and he laughed and said, "I think single malt!"

His parting thoughts at the end of the conversation were, "I have realised that human resilience is far greater than any challenge that is thrown at it. The bigger the challenge, the bigger is the opportunity for a human to evolve and find a solution to that challenge. People who are ready to take up challenges never complain about time, conditions, or anything else. They just find a way around. The greatest example of how big the human resilience is the pandemic of last year. The whole world was about to collapse but look how magnificently the human race has come out of it. Everything that happened during my childhood made me realise that human beings are much more powerful than they know."

It was also in the middle of the conversation that the coronavirus test personnel appeared at Raina's doors. He was in a self-imposed quarantine when this conversation took place.

Everyone's an introvert unless everyone finds their true passion. The story after that is simply everything minus anything being an introvert. **EFY**